Portsmouth Joggers Newsletter Edition 30 Spring 2026

Hi there Joggers.

I have been editing this Newsletter since July 2020, when we were in the throws of Covid and having to lock down at various times and being very restricted as to how many of us could run together. I thought this would be a good way to keep everyone in touch with each other and prevent the club from fading away. It would appear to have worked as when we were able to meet up again, albeit with each group meeting on a different section of the car park, loads of you came back. I asked if the club wanted me to continue with the Newsletter and was told definitely, yes. So I did. As you can see above this is now my 30th Edition. It started as a monthly during lockdown then went to quarterly in Spring 2022. I have enjoyed putting it together and hope you have all enjoyed reading it. I have decided and agreed with the rest of the committee that this will be the last edition edited by me. However with all the info and run reports appearing on Facebook and on the website this now may well be surplus to requirements now. There are certainly fewer people willing to contribute, hence this edition being a bit shorter than usual. If you want it to continue maybe there is someone else out there who would like to take it on.

Thank you all for all your support with this. I will continue to see many of you on Tuesdays and Thursdays when I am running with the Social Group, getting slower with every passing year!

Celia Ed.

Chairperson's Update – March 2026

Hi all, and welcome to the final edition of the newsletter in its current form. I would like to extend my thanks to Celia, for all the hard work she has put into it over the past few years. The newsletter has been a lovely way to keep up-to-date with all the exciting things club members have been up to.

You will have noticed that I haven't been at club nights, or races, for some time now. I have been taking some time out to rest and recover from plantar fasciitis. Hopefully I will be back with you all soon, but I know Sue and the rest of the committee have been doing a great job of looking after things in my absence (thank you team!).

PJC's 50th birthday year is now in full swing. I know you are all eagerly awaiting your commemorative t-shirts, which should be with us by the end of March.

There here have been two Parkrun events: one Burn's night extravaganza, and one takeover. I wasn't able to attend the Burn's night Parkrun, but managed to make it to the takeover on 7th March. It was great to see so many of you out in club kit showcasing what an amazing club we are. Thanks to Tony Quinn for organising, and to everyone who volunteered and took part. The chippy run sounded like a very wet one, but we PJCs are made of strong stuff and were not put off by a small torrential downpour. I assume it made the chippies all the more rewarding, no?

There are lots more 50th birthday events scattered throughout the year, so keep your eye out for more information.

Looking ahead, it is not long now until our 2026 AGM. As is now tradition, the formalities will be followed by a pub quiz, so get revising and we will see you there!

I have been chair for coming up to 2 years now (I'm not sure where the time has gone?). My intention is to serve for one more year, before I step aside to let someone new take over. So, if you think you might be interested in the role, feel free to have a chat with me over the coming year about what is involved!

Enjoy the longer days – Spring is definitely in the air!

Kate

Here is the programme of all the Portsmouth Joggers Jubilee Year Events!

PORTSMOUTH JOGGERS CLUB

Celebrating 50 Years of Running Together

Join us throughout 2026 as we mark half a century of running, friendship, and community spirit with a year full of special events and celebrations!

Golden Anniversary Events

Burns Night Parkrun at Portsmouth Lakeside – Tony Quinn
Come and run in your best Scottish themed kit. Prizes to be won. **Saturday 24th January**

Winter Fish & Chip Run – Tony Conway
Our classic social run. **Thursday 5th February**

Malta Marathon Weekend – Paul Jeffrey (PJ)
A weekend of various races in Malta, choose the one you fancy. **Sunday 22nd February**

Parkrun Takeovers at Portsmouth Lakeside – Tony Quinn
Saturday 7th March (also for Food Bank collection), 9th May, 24th October, and 19th December

Photo Run – Tony Conway
A fun, photo clue-filled adventure around Portsmouth. **Thursday 30th April**

Ace of Pace Run – Tony Quinn
Test your pacing skills – can you hit your target time? **Tuesday 16th June**

Mass Club Run all paces including walking – Tony Conway
All members together for a spectacular club showcase. **Thursday 10th September**

Social Celebration at Portsmouth Rugby Club – Sue Hyson
Our 50th Birthday Party. **Saturday 26th September**

Spanish Running event with Running Crazy – Pete Coote
10k or Half Marathon in Benidorm arranged by 'Running Crazy'. **Saturday 21st November**

Special 50th Year Extras

- 🎽 Exclusive Anniversary Running Top
- 🏅 Unique 50th Birthday Medals for our races
- 🎨 Special Edition Pin Badge

Our Favourite Regular Events with Special Edition Medals / Mementos

Purbrook Ladies 5 Mile – PJC Event Team
Our regular race for ladies. **Sunday 7th June**

Summer Cross Country – PJC Event Team
The summer fun race at Queen Elizabeth Country Park. **Sunday 19th July**

Pub2Pub – PJC Event Team
The Christmas time run at Blendworth. **Sunday 27th December**

For more information about each event please contact the named club member

Two Race Reports

Joggers Park Run Touristing

December 13th dawned dry, bright, and rather chilly, as a group of a dozen or so Joggers gathered in southwest London.
Having crossed the river, we entered the park and the scene changed. Were it not for the rumble of red buses behind us, and the roar of planes on final approach to Heathrow overhead, we would have forgotten we were inside the M25.

A low mist clung to the ground, as though it were too nervous to go any higher, shrouding the bushes, and adding an air of mystery to the atmosphere.

Welcome to Bushy Park. This is the site of the original parkrun in 2004, and still the country's biggest parkrun, regularly hosting 1200-1500 people.
A group of a dozen people, each sporting matching blue and white tops, soon attracted the attention of the volunteers, and our photo was taken, our story told, and we were featured in their Run Report.

With the First Timers Briefing done, we made our way to the start. The Run Director gave their briefing and we were off. The start at Bushy is very wide, far more so than it is deep, allowing us all to cross the start quickly. This funnels gradually down onto the path, after maybe 500m, so there are no bottlenecks, a real bonus given the popularity of this run.

The course itself is a mixture of gravel, tarmac, grass and trail, gloriously flat, and a 5K PB is definitely possible here.
With so many participants, the triple finish funnel is exceptionally well organised, and whilst you may well spend more time in the finish funnel than on the run, you can be sure that your allocated time will be yours, not someone else's.
Everyone having scanned in, we decamped to a café opposite the nearby Hampton Court Palace for breakfast, before heading off home.With it being such a flat course, there were plenty of quick times, with Pete Arnold setting his best time of 2025, Rachel Andrews and I both setting Parkrun PBs.

For anyone else considering making the pilgrimage to Bushy, we parked at Hampton Court Railway Station car park, just over an hour's drive from Portsmouth. It's about a 15 minute walk from the start area, where you will also find toilets. The finish is about 200m away from the start (via the direct route, not the 5km running route!), where there is a baggage drop area, although the 3 square metre tarpaulin does seem a little inadequate for the 1500 runners and walkers.

Would we do it again? Absolutely yes, and a date in May has been pencilled in, especially as there were a couple of Joggers who were unable to make it this time. **Scott Andrews**

Ryde 10 Mile, HRRL 1st February

At 9am on the 1st February, a decent contingent of Joggers, plus support crew, gathered at the Fastcat terminal, ready to cross the Solent to Ryde, for the HRRL 10 mile race.
Race HQ was once again in the Ryde Castle Hotel, with registration being a quick, albeit cramped, process. Bibs suitably fastened to tops, and team photos taken, we lined up ready for the start, with the weather trying to be sunny.

The first kilometre was flat and fast, but shortly after that, we climbed the first of many, many hills, and this seemed to go on forever. Of course, what goes up, must come down, and the race provided many ups and downs over the course of the next 12 or so kilometres. Of particular note was the climb up to the top of the caravan park, with the race photographer at the summit, ready to capture our faces, bright red with exertion.

By this time, a dreary drizzle had descended, the kind that seeps into every nook and cranny of your clothing, yet keeps your temperature nicely under control.
One final steep descent into Seaview was followed by a reasonably flat final 3 kilometres, loosely following the shoreline, to the finish, to the encouragement of the support crew and earlier finishers.

By this time, the rain was falling more earnestly, as though it decided enough was enough, and with the large medal claimed, we stood and cheered in the last few runners, before decamping up the hill (yes, another one) to Wetherspoons. Much food and drink was consumed, an opportunity to spend time with old friends, and to make new ones, before heading back to the ferry terminal, in what was later described as torrential conditions.

Continued on next page

Congratulations to:-

Lewis Taft who was13th overall, Kirsty Whitton who was first in her age category, and Pete Arnold, who saw an improvement over last year's time of over 13 minutes.

Grateful thanks must go to Pete Birch for organising the transport, and accommodating all the special requests.

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So – who's looking forward to next year??? **Scott Andrews**

Ryde 10k Team

Bourne Woods SCCL Run

Southern Cross Country League - Race 4 at Bourne Woods

Race 4 of the Southern Cross Country League took us to Bourne Woods, hosted by Farnham Running Club. We set off from Portsmouth in very rainy weather, with more than a little trepidation about how muddy the course might be. Having run this fixture before, we already knew to expect hills - plenty of them - and there was also some quiet concern about whether the parking field might turn into a quagmire!

Thankfully, by the time we arrived the rain was easing and the parking field was nicely compacted - no bog-rescue required. We pitched the Portsmouth Joggers tent with some concern about getting it down again (always an adventure in itself… those who know, know - and if you don't, come along to a cross-country race and join in the fun of getting it back down again!).

A small but hardy group of Joggers lined up at the start - enough for a men's team, though sadly only two ladies this time, so not enough to field a women's team. The course itself turned out to be far less muddy than anticipated. In fact, some of us picked up more mud at Portsmouth Lakeside parkrun the day before! What it lacked in mud, however, it more than made up for in hills. It was a proper leg-burner, and several of us had forgotten quite how relentless those climbs are.

That said, everyone finished with smiles (and suitably tired legs), and there was a well-earned reward of cake afterwards - an essential part of any cross-country experience.

We headed back to Portsmouth feeling muddy, hilly-humbled, and very pleased with ourselves.

Well done to everyone who took part

Pictures on next page! **Sue Clarke**

Southern Cross Country Team

Bourne Woods

Very muddy shoes after Bourne Woods

Sue Clarke

The Malta Story – 2026 version.

Why Malta?

So the PJC does Malta story actually started in 2013/4, and we have had hundreds of Joggers travelling ever since then (apart from the Covid years).
To sum up the trip (though please keep reading!). Its like an HRRL or league race (or a Parkrun takeover), but extended over several days. Amazing team spirit, support for all, and a great break, mostly in the sunshine!
Fast forward to Wednesday 18th February 2026, the first of the PJC gang (me!) has landed in Malta, looking resplendent in my PJC on Tour, Malta Marathon 2026 edition jacket!
Over the next few days, I will be joined by around 16 more (runners and supporters). That's the beauty of this trip, book your own flights to suit (Air Malta, BA or EasyJet), I used BA going out and EJ coming back as the times suited), book your own accommodation to suit your budget etc…
And I have to admit it was so nice to leave behind a very soggy Engalnd and sample some sunshine (and amazing ice creams!).

Travel and Accomodation.

Public transport (buses and ferries to and from Valetta) are regular, and cheap (£2 most journeys, £3 for the airport bus and the ferries, though returns and multi use tickets reduce those costs).

We all stay in Sliema, which has loads of hotels and apartments, most quite cheap, unless you fancy 5 stars!! Plus loads of places to eat, drink, buy ice cream, and a decent array of shops if that's what you want to do!

The Races.

Choice of Marathon, Half or Walkathon, which is actually the Half but with less pressure!! There is a cut off, but from my vantage point of my hotel balcony overlooking the finish, no-one actually did get timed out.
They say you have 5hrs for the marathon, and 3 hours 45 mins for the half and walkathon. In reality, add another 45 mins to those times, as they kept the finish line open for best part of an extra hour. And same in 2025,
so it wasn't just a one off thing.

Both routes start in M'dina, the old capital and on top of a hill. There are buses organised from Sliema to get everyone to the start (not free, but only £5), which is great, and lovely kit bags to take your spare clobber back to the finish in Sliema.

It's a fast course, with the start being high up, then overall its 600 feet downhill! The Half really is downhill, the full has a few lumps in the extra 13.1 miles of loops, about 700 up (and 1300 feet down therefore). We will gloss over the few little hills near the end of course

Numbers? This year was their biggest ever, with 1300 in the marathon, and 3 times that number in the half. The PJC split was 4-8 in that respect.

The marathoners start 90 mins ahead of the halfers, and the routes merge with 10 miles to go, and I must admit it was a welcome sight to join the half marathon runners, plus of course seeing a few fellow Joggers (more than once due to a switchback on the route).

Start times are early to beat the heat, which works but I must admit getting up at 3.30 was a bit of a shock to the system! Best advice, eat breakfast the night before, and set your alarm!!

Note, there is also a 5k. Its also run on the Sunday morning, it's something new started last year. Starts and finishes in Sliema, think Lakeside Parkrun in terms of numbers and spread of finish times.

PJC Traditions.

We are developing a few traditions now over the last couple of years.

Saturday Parkrun. Well, there isn't actually a parkrun in Malta, but we do one anyway!! We run as a group, in club colours, (well, some of us), at 9.00 Saturday. PJ gave the race briefing….

Valetta Gun Salute at Noon Saturday. This does take place other days too, but quite a few jump on the ferry to watch this.

Post race prosecco. Helped (again) by the sunny weather on the Sunday, we all stood by the finish cheering in our clubmates, drinking a few bubbles, and generally dissecting our various race experiences!

Post race team meal.
We book a team meal on the Sunday evening. As consummate professionals, we have of course all abstained from sampling the local beer (CISK) and happy hour cocktails pre-race, so now is our chance..!

Several of us meet up for meals and/or drinks in the evenings too, and we also share ideas on day trips, sightseeing etc, so some joint trips and entertainment if you want.

Medals and Awards.
Last year's medal was huge, but it was their 40th, so a bit special. Except, this year's was even better, and bigger! Nice finishers t shirt too, and free race photos to download. And there are awards – over the years, Joggers have collected quite a few. Quite impressive, by a stroke of luck I managed to get 2nd place in Age Group, and get a pretty large trophy – you should see the size of the 1st place!

Summary.

Such a great time, the race almost becomes incidental, though hats off to Pete Arnold and Joy Barker, who both got PB's in the Half, and Jackie Nicholson, who finished her first marathon (automatic PB!). If you know those 3, it was a reflection of just how hard they had trained for this, and so well deserved.

2027 anyone?

If interested, message or speak to myself or PJ /Pauline Jeffries, and get planning, or even training!

Steven Wooldridge

Well I think that's it! I have enjoyed editing the Newsletter but not so much the nagging to get enough content to make it worthwhile. However the nagging has been productive because loads of you have written wonderful reports and observations, shared your triumphs and struggles and generally encouraged your fellow Joggers. There is no reason why the wonderful race reports you have been sending to me couldn't be put on our Facebook page instead, some already are. There are often photos so may be those who put up photos could put up a few details about the race to encourage others to do the next one.

If someone out there feels that the Newsletter needs to keep going I am happy so send them the format I have been using and help in any way I can. As I said at the beginning I have done 30 editions since I started in 2020 during the dark days of Covid restrictions and feel that it has served its' purpose. The club survived everything Covid threw at us and we came out stronger than ever!

A huge thank you for all your support over the last 7 years, I really couldn't have done it without you all.

Keep on Jogging!

Celia Oxley - Editor